Chloe Michael (Sutton)

Commercial Finance & Operations Leader · Challenger FMCG

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PROFILE

Commercial finance and operations leader with over a decade in challenger FMCG brands, including HIPPEAS, Dalston's and Vita Coco. At HIPPEAS ($65 million, 80+ SKUs, 4 co-manufacturers) I own P&L forecasting to gross margin for the US and EBITDA for the UK, present monthly reforecasts to the board, and build the business case behind every new product, customer and supplier decision.

I started in finance and moved into running the operations it reports on: co-manufacturing, inventory, logistics and S&OP. Knowing where the numbers come from means forecasts that hold up, commentary the business can act on, and cost savings that stick.

KEY RESULTS

−9% logistics cost	Business case, tender and negotiation for a new US 3PL at HIPPEAS
+4.8pp export margin	New secondary European co-manufacturer at HIPPEAS
~80 launches costed	30 UK and 50 US SKUs, each with a margin case and delivered to plan
MAPE ~50% → ~70%	US demand planning process built from scratch, with service level held at 96%
7 → 4 weeks on hand	Inventory cut, releasing working capital
−52% unresolved claims	Customer claims process rebuilt at Vita Coco

CORE STRENGTHS

- P&L forecasting, budgets and monthly reforecasts vs budget, forecast and prior year
- Board and leadership reporting with performance commentary
- Business cases, costings and margin analysis: gross margin, COGS, cost-to-serve
- Month-end close, balance sheet reconciliations, order-to-cash and VAT
- S&OP, demand and supply planning, forecast accuracy
- Co-manufacturer, 3PL and supplier tendering and negotiation
- Inventory and working capital management
- Lean Six Sigma Green Belt

Systems: advanced Excel modelling, Dynamics 365 Business Central, SAP, Xero, QuickBooks, Unleashed, EDI, SQL (learning), GitHub (basic), AI-driven analysis (Claude)

EXPERIENCE

HIPPEAS Snacks

5 yrs 11 mos

Operations & Finance Director – UK & US

Dec 2023 – present

- Own P&L forecasting to gross margin (US) and EBITDA (UK); track performance against budget, forecast and prior year, and present monthly reforecasts and the operational plan behind them to the board.
- Build the costings, margin analysis and business case for every new product, customer and supplier, giving leadership a clear recommendation to approve or decline.
- Project-manage NPD and EPD end to end, aligning QC, finance, sales and supply chain on volumes and timings: 30 new UK and 50 new US SKUs delivered.
- Supported the Quality team on the operational response to a quality incident that came close to a product recall.
- Own the finance month-end cycle, including balance sheet reconciliations, and UK order-to-cash; managed Italian VAT on exports from Italy.
- Partner US Sales on route-to-market decisions, using trade, promotional spend and logistics analysis to show where margin is won and lost.
- Ran the business case, tender and negotiation for a new US 3PL warehouse, cutting total logistics costs by 9%.
- Sourced and onboarded a secondary European co-manufacturer, lifting export SKU margin by 4.8pp and building supply resilience.
- Set up the US demand planning process, from an Excel model to a software implementation: forecast accuracy (MAPE) up from ~50% to ~70%, service level held at 96%, inventory down from 7 to 4 weeks on hand.

- Set co-manufacturer utilisation strategy to cut COGS and fulfilment costs while minimising inventory working capital.
- Use AI tools (Claude) to speed up cost analysis, ROI assessment and forecasting.

Operations & Finance Director – UK Apr 2021 – Nov 2023 · Head of UK Operations, Jan – Mar 2021

- Took ownership of the UK finance month-end cycle and led the UK annual audit.
- Ran the UK Dynamics 365 Business Central project and supported the US implementation.
- Ran UK S&OP and built demand-forecasting partnerships with UK retailer supply chain teams.
- Led the UK supply chain's move to a distributor model with zero inventory write-offs.
- Owned the warehouse relationship end to end, including a cost-saving 3PL switch.
- Managed co-packers, suppliers, production planning, and UK and EU regulatory compliance, including HFSS reformulation and multilingual packaging for Europe.
- Line-managed 2 people.

Dalston's Soda 1 yr 8 mos

Head of Operations Apr 2019 – Dec 2020

- Managed an outsourced accounting team and ran month-end processing.
- Managed S&OP, including collaborative forecasting with grocery supply chain teams that kept stock right and launches on track.
- Owned the end-to-end supply chain for a challenger soft drinks brand, launching into Europe, the Middle East and the USA.
- Led NPD from concept to launch and set up a secondary European co-manufacturer to build supply resilience.

Vita Coco 3 yrs 10 mos

Supply Chain Manager Jul 2017 – Mar 2019

- Built a weekly KPI suite covering customer forecast accuracy, days on hand and a promotional tracker.
- Managed supply planning across multiple European co-packers and delivered 15 new SKUs across ambient and chilled.
- Directed raw material procurement and managed stock transitions to limit excess and obsolete inventory; ran SAP period-end stock reconciliations.

Commercial Finance Analyst Nov 2016 – Jun 2017

- Produced all sales reporting against budget and forecast with the Sales team, to gross margin.
- Managed customer credit claims, cutting unresolved claims by 52%.
- Owned the EDI system and onboarded new customers and warehouses.

Sales Ledger Executive May 2015 – Oct 2016

- Order-to-invoice processing, remittance allocation, stock reconciliations and credit control.

Martorana Snacks 2 yrs

Finance and Supply Chain Assistant Apr 2013 – Apr 2015

- Tracked cost-to-serve, processed orders and invoices, and ran bank and stock reconciliations.

Advisory

- Mentored SURREAL's Head of Operations through a weekly touch base; advised NICE and wype* on supply chain.